

Retrospective on Issue-Centric Organizing Effort

The Starkville Community's Response to the 2026 Cryptomining Facility Project

During the period of late June to early August of 2026 (about 2 months), local residents in Starkville and the surrounding area organized a group opposed to a cryptocurrency mining facility proposed for construction in the city. That effort had the intended impact, as the facility was denied by the Planning and Zoning commission on August 11, and the proposing company pulled their own special exemption request application from consideration before the subsequent Board of Aldermen meeting.

This document is to summarize the organizing techniques and tactics used in that effort to provide some level of insight and guidance for other potential organizers and caring community members that are driven to work on future efforts in our area.

September 13, 2026

1. Purpose

I intend for this document to serve as a post-event analysis report on what was done during this work (from my perspective and those I may interview) for the benefit of myself, my fellow organizers, other organizers-to-be, and the community at large.

This document may serve as a potential list of do's and don't's for others looking to make similar organizational efforts in Starkville, or maybe even perhaps municipalities in general that are similar to our own (e.g., small, college town, caring population).

Finally, I am writing this because I was asked to, and I like to be helpful.

I originally had a section on the timeline of this issue, but I realized that the exact timeline is not really important for a few reasons:

1. Every situation is different; the timelines will differ, sometimes drastically, between different companies, local governments, and local communities. Why our timeline worked may not apply.
2. The order of these steps isn't super relevant. The point is that we organized and organized (somewhat) effectively, not that we held some certain number of meetings within a certain amount of time, or sent a certain amount of messages.
3. Organizing is more "fuzzy" than most problems I usually work on. With my engineering background, I'm used to following a certain list of steps when troubleshooting an issue or working on a solution to a problem. These efforts were most certainly not like that, but I believe the general insights we offer below may help offer guidance!

If you are interested in a timeline of big events, you can see the timeline on website^o, but this timeline is from before the P&Z meeting on 2026-08-11 and has not been updated since then. For anyone still interested in a more detailed play-by-play, I may be able to provide a timeline of key organizational events later.

1.1. Post-hoc Reflection on Why This Worked

- [] Incorporate [[crypto mine debrief - other person's input]]

Another resident and myself collaborated on the following list of what happened here we believe was important to how the community reached the outcome we desired¹.

This list is not exhaustive, and more could be revealed from further discussions, but I wanted to get *something* out to people and not ruminate on this forever!

This is broken down into two main parts: things we could control, and things we could not control, and are outlined as follows:

- Things We Could Control
 - Attending local government events
 - Research
 - Communication

¹While we believe this result was in the best interest of the community, others may disagree. Ultimately, the city is meant to follow the will of the people within it, and we believed the will just needed to "speak up" a bit more in this case.

- Divide-and-conquer
- In-person meetings
- Over-preparing
- Things We Could Not Control
 - The specifics that made this project such a contentious one
 - Our local government structure, rules, and sentiments
 - Existing connections between people

These are discussed in more detail below.

- [] finish organizing discussion of these terms!!!

1.1.1. Things We Could Not Control

1.1.1.1. This Specific Issue

Data centers are currently in the national spotlight due to things like “artificial intelligence”. Cryptocurrency as well is a hot topic for some groups.

In addition, this proposed facility would have been located pretty centrally to the city (see [here](#)[°] for pictures²⁾), meaning it potentially would impact many different groups, including businesses, animals, and businesses.

I believe that this basically led to a kind of “perfect storm” of opposition to the project, including:

- those concerned with resource usage locally and impacts to utilities bills,
- those that oppose crypto currency on a moral basis,
- those concerned about potential noise impacts to animals and wildlife,
- those that are concerned about the power usage from an environmental standpoint (emissions from power generation),
- people concerned with the obfuscated ownership structure of the project, and
- those that are concerned about the usage of capacity of the substation for cryptocurrency instead of other industries that provide services or produce physical goods.

These parties spanned political parties, religions, and other dimensions we are so typically divided.

This broad support for our cause (opposition to the project) led to overwhelming numbers at the Planning and Zoning Commission.

Without the organization of people and speeches beforehand, I would bet that there still would have been more people present to oppose the project than the number that are normally present at the Planning and Zoning Commission or Board of Aldermen meetings.

It may not have been as overwhelming of a response if the organizing had not have occurred, but I wanted to point out how this specific issue itself was such an almost toxic topic in and of itself that the community would have still done something else to organize before the Board of Aldermen meeting at least.

²⁾This website may be deactivated by the time you read this, but you can find more information out if you care. You could email starkvillecmf@gmail.com or you could ask whoever you got this from for more info if needed.

1.2. Extensive research and argument vetting

A large part of our effort surrounding this issue was research on this and similar facilities. We had subgroups working on researching utilities usage (electricity and water), pollution (noise, heat, and air), and company identity and a group discussing speechwriting. All of these were on top of the main group where general information and discussions were had.

Several types of information were shared:

- official documents,
- news articles,
- our own written words,
- and other sources/repositories of information.

1.2.1. My Background and Positioning Coming into this Situation

I am risk averse, commitment avoidant³, and anti-traditionalist⁴.

In these aspects, I likely should have been set up to not care about this problem, or at least not want to devote a lot of time to it.

However, I care a lot about people, animals, and the environment in which we live.

This care coupled with the risk-averse nature means that the possibility of harm coming to my fellow community members was greatly alarming to me.

I honestly did not know enough at the time to weigh in on the discussion, but I started to look into it and ask questions where possible.

Within the last two years, I have developed an appreciation for other people and the benefits (social, emotional, spiritual, and sometimes financial) that having a lot of friends and acquaintances can have⁵.

I started doing my best to get into places where I could interact with others, including volunteer work, my own business helping people directly, and membership in a business networking group⁶ and several local organizations trying to help our community.

I've made more friends and acquaintances in the past 2 years than I had in the previous 5 or so (which isn't saying much due to the COVID years...).

I like talking to people and helping them work through their problems, even if I may not have a direct solution.

I now understand that my being so open to conversation and approaching people allowed me to reach out to others that I saw as like-minded and similarly caring that would help us figure out what to do.

We formed many layers of groups and connections between our individual circles of influence (friends, family, religious and non-religious institutions, etc.) that led to where we ultimately ended up in this work.

We may have gotten there eventually, but I believe that my training to lower the "activation

³Ask my wife...

⁴Not against traditions, but against following traditions for no reason. For more discussion, look into the idea of Chesterson's Fence^o.

⁵"It's not what you know; it's who you know" seems at least partly true.

⁶Business Networking International, or BNI for short.

energy of social interaction”⁷ allowed us to make some core connections early on in the effort that gave us ample time to grow our group and work.

Ideally, start early every time, but growing fast in limited time is also a way to get there.

- [] analogy to leaving earlier or speeding to get somewhere.

....

Compulsively driven to pick up litter (which has not changed).

....

- [] finish here

1.3. problems in other efforts we didn't have much here

1.3.1. Other Core Team Backgrounds

Two academics from different disciplines.

Some with software/computer experience.

Some making outreach materials.

All quite driven by their values.

⁷This is pretty abstract, but here is a TED talk^o basically discussing what I mean here.